

YU ZHAO

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EDUCATION

Pompeu Fabra University & Barcelona Institute for Global Health (ISGlobal)

Sep 2023 – Present

Ph.D. in Public Health (Environmental Epidemiology)

Barcelona, Spain

- **Doctoral topic:** Heat Exposure during Pregnancy and Prenatal Brain Development and Postnatal Neurodevelopment: The Role of Placental Hemodynamics and Placental Epigenome.
- **Supervisors:** Payam Dadvand, Mariona Bustamante, and Marta Cosin.
- **Research population:** Barcelona Life Study Cohort (BiSC).
- **Research funding:** European Research Council, European Union Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (785994, AirNB project), and Health Effects Institute (4959-RFA17-1/18-1, FRONTIER project).

Sun Yat-sen University — Master of Medicine

Sep 2020 – Jul 2023

Public Health (Maternal, Child and Adolescent Health)

Guangzhou, China

- **GPA:** 3.50/4.0 (86.6/100).
- **Master's research:** Exposure to greenspace and visual impairment in Chinese schoolchildren; supervised by Yajun Chen.

Anhui Medical University — Bachelor of Medicine

Sep 2015 – Jul 2020

Preventive Medicine

Hefei, China

- **GPA:** 3.55/4.0 (87.8/100).
- **Core coursework:** Epidemiology, Health Statistics, Women's Health Care, Child Health Care, Nutrition and Food Hygiene, Occupational Health and Occupational Medicine, Environmental Hygiene, and Public Health Skills Training.

RESEARCH PROFILE

Predoctoral researcher at Pompeu Fabra University and ISGlobal investigating how *heat exposure during pregnancy* may influence *fetal brain development* and children's neurodevelopment. Combines environmental data with statistical, machine-learning, and molecular methods to explore possible pathways involving *placental blood flow* and *DNA methylation*.

PUBLICATIONS

- [Air pollution and fetal brain morphological development: a prospective cohort study](#) 
Laura GH*, Yu Z*, et al.
The Lancet Planetary Health, 2025;9(6):e480–e490.
- [Urban greenspace and visual acuity in schoolchildren: a large prospective cohort study in China](#) 
Wenwen B*, Yu Z*, et al.
Environment International, 2024 Feb;184:108423.
- [Association between greenspace and blood pressure: A systematic review and meta-analysis](#) 
Yu Z*, Wenwen B*, et al.
The Science of the Total Environment, 2022 Apr 15;817:152513.
- [Face-to-face physical activity incorporated into dietary intervention for overweight/obesity in children and adolescents: a Bayesian network meta-analysis](#) 
Liang JH, Zhao Y, Chen YC, et al.
BMC Medicine, 2022;20:325.
- [Development and Validation of a Nomogram-Based Prognostic Model to Predict High Blood Pressure in Children and Adolescents—Findings From 342,736 Individuals in China](#) 
Liang JH, Zhao Y, Chen YC, et al.
Frontiers in Cardiovascular Medicine, 2022;9:884508.
- [Air pollution and systemic immune biomarkers in early life: A systematic review](#) 
Carvajal V, Jorques Molla JV, Luo Y, Zhao Y, Moncunill G, Gascon M.
Environmental Research, 2025;269:120838.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Predoctoral Researcher — Barcelona Life Study Cohort (BiSC)

Sep 2023 – Present

Pompeu Fabra University & Barcelona Institute for Global Health (ISGlobal)

Barcelona, Spain

- Estimate indoor and outdoor temperature exposure for BiSC participants using advanced statistical and machine-learning models.
- Examine associations between temperature exposure and placental DNA methylation to investigate potential molecular mechanisms connecting prenatal heat exposure with neurodevelopment.
- Integrate predictive modeling, exposure assessment, placental hemodynamics, and molecular epidemiology across the doctoral project.

Master's Researcher — Greenspace and Visual Health

Sep 2020 – Jul 2023

Sun Yat-sen University

China

- Investigated the association between greenspace exposure and visual impairment in Chinese schoolchildren under the supervision of Yajun Chen.

HONORS AND AWARDS

- First Prize for Abstract, ISEE Young Conference, Rennes, France (June 2024)
- First-class Scholarship for Postgraduate Students, Sun Yat-sen University (2022)
- Second-class Scholarship for Postgraduate Students, Sun Yat-sen University (2021)